Janmabhoomi. The 1990s, following the demolition of the Babri Masjid, witnessed what many have described as the worst riots of post-independence India—in Mumbai, Surat, Ahmedabad, Kanpur, Delhi and elsewhere. (And of course, unrelated to Hindutva, India also suffered the grotesque anti-Sikh riots of 1984, when mobs egged on by some leaders affiliated with the ruling Congress, and claiming to be revenging the assassination of Indira Gandhi by her Sikh bodyguards murdered 2,800 innocent Sikh civilians across India, including 2,100 in Delhi.)

Since the ascent of the BJP to power, the forces unleashed by the dominance of Hindutva have resulted in many incidents of violence. In one grim reckoning, more than fifty individuals have been killed in anti-minority acts of violence since mid-2014, and dozens of others stripped, beaten and humiliated. Particularly haunting is the story of fifteen-year-old Junaid Khan, returning home on a crowded train after buying new clothes for Id, who was stabbed repeatedly because he was Muslim and thrown off the train to bleed to death on the tracks. (Specific cases related to 'cow vigilantism' are discussed later.) Headlines have spoken continually of riots and killing, Hindu against Muslim, of men being slaughtered because of the mark on a forehead or the absence of a foreskin.

THE POLITICS OF DIVISION

There are essentially two kinds of politics in India: the politics of division and the politics of unity. The latter has increasingly been taken for granted and so the former has by far the greater momentum, as politicians seek to slice and dice the electorate into ever-smaller configurations of caste, language and religion, the better to appeal to such particularist identities in the quest for votes. But this resort to violence is a new low in our political life. The attacks on Muslim and (earlier) Christian families, the vandalism of their places of worship, the destruction of homes and livelihoods, and the horrific rapes, mutilations and burnings alive that have occurred, have nothing to do with religious beliefs—neither those of the victims nor of their attackers. They are instead part of a contemptible political project whose closest equivalent can in fact be found in the Islamist terrorism the Hindutva supporters